Plain Girl Versus the Demon

By Amy Poehler

AMY: **(Pg 15-28)** I hate how I look. That is the mantra we repeat over and over again. Sometimes we whisper it quietly and other times we shout it out loud in front of a mirror. I hate how I look. I hate how my face looks my body looks I am too fat or too skinny or too tall or too wide or my legs are too stupid and my face is too smiley or my teeth are dumb and my nose is serious and my stomach is being so lame. Then we think. "I am so ungrateful. I have arms and legs and I can walk and I have strong nail beds and I am alive and I am so selfish and I have to read Man's Search for Meaning again and call my parents and volunteer more and reduce my carbon footprint and why am I [so] self-obsessed [and] ugly. No wonder I hate how I look! I hate how I am!"

INTRODUCTION

Recently, Glamour Magazine did a survey of approximately 300 women asking them to share their thoughts about their bodies. Surprisingly, or perhaps not, 97% of the women reported having at least one "I hate my body" moment.

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Amy Poehler explores this mental state in Plain Girl Versus the Demon from her memoir Yes, Please.

AMY: That voice that talks badly to you is a demon voice. This very patient and determined demon shows up in your bedroom one day and refuses to leave. You are six or twelve or fifteen and you look in the mirror and you hear a voice so awful and mean that it takes your breath away. It tells you that you are fat and ugly and you don't deserve love. And the scary part is the demon is your own voice. But it doesn't sound like you. It sounds like a strangled and seductive version of you. Think Darth Vader or an angry Lauren Bacall. The good news is there are ways to make it stop talking. The bad news is it never goes away. If you are lucky, you can live a life where the demon is generally forgotten, relegated to a back shelf in a closet next to your old field hockey equipment. You may even have days or y ears when you think the demon is gone. But it is not. It is sitting very quietly, waiting for you.

[It] is patient. It says, "Take your time." It says, "Go fall in love and exercise and surround yourself with people

who make you feel beautiful." It says, "Don't worry, I'll wait."

And then one day, you go through a breakup or you can't lose weight, or you look at your reflection in a soup spoon and that slimy bugger is back. It moves its sour mouth up to your ear and reminds you that you are fat and ugly and don't deserve love

I had a lucky childhood. My demon didn't live in my room. My demon just walked around my neighborhood. I grew up with a naturally pretty but very earthy mother who never told me to put on makeup or change my outfit. I didn't have the king of mother who flirted with my friends or wore tight jeans.

In middle school I was small and flat chested, which was also a lucky break. You can kind of slip around unnoticed that way, which is exactly what you want. I was made fun of for being short, but it was mostly by boys who were shorter than me. I rarely brushed my hair and I was skinny. I bordered on being a tomboy, but not enough to be labeled one. It was a wonderful but short-lived time when I was in my body but not critical of it. If

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you ever want to see heaven, watch a bunch of young girls play. They are all sweat and skinned knees. Energy and open faces. My demon would receive my school picture and maybe gently suggest I "do something about those eyebrows," but for the most part it left me alone. I felt safe in the middle – a girl who had a perfectly fine face but no one that drew any attention.

Then I started caring about boys and the demon pulled into my driveway. Once high school started, I began to see the real difference between the plain and the pretty. Boys, who were going through their own battles started to point out things about me I hadn't yet noticed. One told me I looked like a frog. Some told me I smiled like a Muppet. A senior told me to stop looking at him with my "big, weird eyes." I looked in the mirror at my flat chest and my freckles and heard a sound. It was the demon, suitcase in hand. He moved in and demanded the top bunk.

I cannot, in good faith, pretend I have fallen in love with how I look. The demon still visits me often. I wish I could tell you that being on television or having a nice

picture in a magazine suddenly washes all of those thoughts away, but it really doesn't. I wish I were taller or had leaner hands and a less crazy smile. I don't like my legs, especially. My nose is great. I like my giant eyes, but they can get crazy. My hair is too thin for my liking.

[But] I had already made a decision early on that I would be a plain girl with tons of personality, and accepting it made everything a lot easier. If you are lucky, there is a moment in your life when you have some say as to what your currency is going to be I decided early on it was not going to be my looks. I have spent a lifetime coming to terms with this idea and I would say I am about 15 to 20 percent there. Which I think is great progress. I am not underestimating the access I get as a Blond, white lady from America.

Decide what your currency is early. Let go of what you will never have. People who do this are happier.

Being considered beautiful can be tough. Beautiful people can get objectified and underestimated. They didn't do anything to earn their genes so they have to

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struggle to prove they are more than their hot bods. People assume they are happy, and most times this is not true. Plus, some beautiful people get a little addicted to being told they are beautiful and have real trouble when they get older, get less attention, or have their spouse cheat on them with someone considered "plain."

Hopefully as you get older, you start to learn how to live with your demon. It's hard at first. Some people give their demon so much room that there is no space in their head for love. They feed their demon and it gets really strong and then it makes them stay in abusive relationships or starve their beautiful bodies. But sometimes, you get a little older and get a little bored of the demon. Through good therapy and friends and self-love you can practice treating the demon like a hacky, annoying cousin. Maybe a day even comes when you are getting dressed for a fancy event and it whispers, "You aren't pretty," and you go, "I know, I know, now let me find my earrings." Sometimes you say, "Demon, I promise you I will let you remind me of my ugliness, but I will check in later."

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Other times I take a more direct approach. When the demon starts to slither my way and say bad *stuff* about me I turn around and say, “Hey, Cool it. Amy is my friend. Don’t talk about her like that.” Sticking up for ourselves in the same way we would one of our friends is a hard but satisfying thing to do. Sometimes it works.

Even demons gotta sleep.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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